



INSIDER'S GUIDE TO AFRICAN SAFARIS



Young male lion. 📷 RIDE KENYA.



INTRODUCTION

*So you've always had a safari on the bucket list—
but how do you actually go about planning one?*

Well, there are two answers to that question. You can do it yourself, or you can use a tour operator to make the plans for you.

If you're confident of the type of safari you'd like to do, the country (our countries) you'd like to visit, and have plenty of time to do the research, you can organise a great holiday yourself. Tripadvisor will take away some of the guess work of finding the best camps and lodges, and international and regional flights are easy enough to book. However, it's important not to underestimate the more complicated business of getting from place to place once you reach your destination—booking internal bush flights needs a bit of insider knowledge. Ending up on one side of the Masai Mara when the camp you're aiming for is half a days' drive away won't endear you to your travelling companions. That said, if you have the time and aptitude then it's perfectly possible these days, with the help of the Internet, to book your own African safari.

If the DIY route doesn't appeal to you, then using a tour operator is your other option. The snag here is how to choose, from the many reputable operators out there, who is the best for you.

THE KEY QUESTIONS TO PONDER ARE:

- Has the specialist been to Africa and how well do they really know the countries and activities you are considering?
- Do they offer the style and quality of safari you want?
- Would you enjoy working with this person/company? A look at the 'about us' page should provide some clues.
- How long has the operator been in business and how do they make money?
- Does the company offer its clients financial protection?
- Do they support responsible tourism?
- Can you see previous clients' testimonials?

Once you've chosen your supplier you'll need to work out whether the holiday wish list dictates the budget or whether the budget dictates the proposed itinerary. A good specialist will be able to work either way. Our top tips:

- **GET RECOMMENDATIONS:** Word of mouth referral is one of the most powerful ways to source the best.
- **BE OPEN-MINDED ABOUT DESTINATIONS:** Any country done well will be amazing but some require bigger budgets than others.

Whether you've booked your own trip or are planning to use a specialist operator, we hope this guide will answer many of the questions you're likely to encounter during the process of booking, preparing and actually travelling on safari.

Happy reading!

Proud male lion, Botswana. 📷 GREAT PLAINS CONSERVATION



part I

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Bold and beautiful, South African Airways is the country's national flag carrier.  WIKIMEDIA





— TRAVELLING TO AFRICA

For many of you getting to Africa is a relatively simple matter, especially if you have been before.

We can arrange flights to fit with the itinerary, making sure that the whole process is seamless and involves little input on your part. We can also fit an itinerary into the flights you have arranged yourselves. If you prefer to organise your own flights based on the itinerary you decide on, we'll give you all the information you need to book the right ones. We are happy to check what you arrange, to make sure it fits the itinerary precisely. Here are a few top tips to minimise stress and maximise your travel value:

- **MOST CARRIERS ISSUE FLIGHT SCHEDULES 11 MONTHS AHEAD OF TIME.** To get the best deals, from us or when booking yourself, we recommend arranging the itinerary as far ahead as you can.
- **USE YOUR AIR MILES.** If you have air miles, by all means use them. You need to be booking well in advance, typically a little under a year. There may be limitations as to when and on what route they can be used, but we can generally fit in with whatever dates you can obtain.
- **IF YOU DO ARRANGE YOUR OWN FLIGHTS,** please send us all the details. We will double check dates and times, and we'll also pass the information on to our colleagues in Africa who will be expecting you.

TRAVEL WITHIN AFRICA

Foot, camel, bus and boat, there are plenty of options for travelling between destinations in Africa, but the snag with the aforementioned is that they are a wee bit slow.



Enjoy a bird's-eye view of Africa as you travel. 📷 BEVERLY JOUBERT, GREAT PLAINS CONSERVATION

It's such an enormous continent that using a small aircraft is by far the easiest, swiftest and safest way to travel from place to place. It's also a very cost effective way to go.

Most itineraries include one or more internal flights in some sort of Cessna, perfect for use in the bush, allowing you to arrive direct into the most remote wilderness regions, right into the heart of the real action. Travelling in relative comfort, with a pilot who can also act as a guide, you'll gain some fascinating insights into the land you are traversing. As well as being much quicker than driving, you can see the land unfold from the air, get a better feel for the scale of Africa, and have panoramic views of its epic landscapes. Flying past mountains, through valleys, over herds of wildlife, local villages, and forests is truly memorable and part of the overall safari experience.

Light aircraft flights are generally shared with others, which helps keep the costs down, but if you would prefer your own private aircraft we can certainly arrange it for you. Very often, scheduled services operate via a number of different airstrips in each destination, and you may land and take off several times before reaching

your own stop, a little like a London bus. Bush flying is a relaxed affair, with no formal check in (the pilot typically just has a list of names), no baggage handling, and no officious airport announcements. Your baggage won't go missing either. Furthermore, if there's a delay, you can generally relax in the sun, admiring a wonderful view. You'll travel from your safari camp to the bush airstrip by way of a leisurely game drive with your guide, and he waits with you until he's seen you safely on board and taken off. It will seem like no time at all before you arrive at your next location, where you alight from the plane to be met by another professional guide and a friendly smile. You will never be left alone at an airstrip, and someone will always be there to meet you on arrival.

Light aircraft are professionally maintained to internationally accepted standards, and flown by expertly trained and very experienced bush pilots. The types of aircraft chosen for the job have been in use for decades in such roles, and have proven their capabilities in African conditions. They allow travel within each country to be comfortable and trouble free.

SEASONS & WEATHER

Africa really is staggeringly enormous; all three of the tropic lines pass through it, with the equator roughly bisecting it.

In general, it's winter down south when it's summer here, and during our winter much of Africa is at its hottest and wettest. Winters tend towards cool and dry, and are for many the best time to travel. Africa is a big place, and China, India and the UK would fit comfortably into the 15 countries in which we work, so it'll be no surprise to learn that the climate varies greatly. One of Kenya's wet seasons coincides with a dry time in Botswana, and while cyclones batter Madagascar it's glorious gentle summer on South Africa's southern coast. In general, dry season means more visitors, good visibility, and excellent game viewing thanks to concentrated wildlife gathering at the remaining water sources. The wet, or green, season brings taller grass, dense bush, and lush landscapes, fewer visitors and lower prices although conditions can mean it's a little less comfortable.

Here are some general [seasonal guidelines](#) for Southern and Eastern Africa:

SOUTHERN AFRICA

**BOTSWANA, MALAWI, MOZAMBIQUE, NAMIBIA,
SOUTH AFRICA, ZAMBIA, ZIMBABWE**

Southern Africa's dry season runs from May to the end of October. The heat builds up as October progresses, and November usually brings some biblical thunderstorms, which drop revitalising rain. The rains are the harbinger of the arrival of many migratory bird species and, in some places like the Kalahari Desert, several hundred thousand antelope and zebra in search of fresh grazing. The rainfall is on and off until the end of March and sometimes into April, with most in January and February. It's generally short sharp showers or storms that clear the air, cool things down, and don't badly interfere with wildlife viewing. Even during the 'wet' season the weather is better than it ever is here, with many days having clear skies and sunshine, and remember too that the region has some of the lowest average rainfall on earth.



Thirteen countries—including the United States, China, India, and Eastern Europe—fit snugly into the surface area of Africa.

EAST AFRICA

**KENYA, RWANDA, TANZANIA,
UGANDA, ZANZIBAR**

East Africa has two wet and two dry seasons: November and December are the short rains, a bit like Southern Africa, while in April and May the long rains come. December to February and June to October are mostly dry, and the best times to visit. Many safari camps close during the long rains, and some also for the short rains, as the rain gets very heavy making the tracks in the national parks difficult to negotiate.

The peak months in East Africa are July and August, and reserves can be rather crowded. It's worth talking to a top flight tour operator who knows how to avoid the masses, and who can guarantee that on your safari, you'll see far more animals than people.

PACKING FOR AFRICA

Deciding what to take to Africa will depend on where you are going and what you are doing. You may also have to take into account baggage allowance limitations. There are however some items which are vital for making sure that you have a rewarding, trouble free, fun, and safe safari:



Remember, less is often more when packing for safari so seek advice about clothing and equipment.  [ROBIN POPE SAFARIS](#)

IDENTIFICATION: A valid passport with enough blank pages, your visa (if necessary), and one other form of photo ID.

PHOTOCOPIES OF YOUR ID DOCUMENTS: Take them with you, just in case you mislay the original. It's worth giving a copy of your documents to a friend or member of your family at home before you leave.

A GOOD CAMERA: Technological advances mean that digital cameras deliver the most incredible results in almost anyone's hands these days. Even beginners can turn out pictures that National Geographic would be pleased with. Wherever you go you will find scenery, wildlife, birds, landscapes, and structures that beg to be photographed so please make sure you bring your good camera and suitable lens(es). We've given more details in the camera section [below](#).

SPARE CAMERA BATTERY: There's nothing worse than a battery failing out in the bush, and it's pretty much impossible to find a new one out there. Please remember to take a spare battery with you, as well as a charger to suit it.

SUFFICIENT SPARE CAMERA MEMORY CARDS: Even if you have travelled extensively before, you will be surprised by how many pictures you will take on a safari. It's likely that you will be massively enthusiastic from the word go, and fill several cards before you know it, resulting in a possible lack of capacity when you see some amazing sights towards the end of the holiday.

SUNSCREEN: The sun is always strong in Africa, whether you are high up a mountain or beside the sea. You will find that you burn easily whether the sun is in a clear sky or behind a cloud, and it can also get extremely hot in some places. It's a good idea to bring along plenty of high factor sunscreen.

A HEADTORCH: Normal torches are heavy and take up space. You'll find a small headtorch invaluable as a reading light and to help find the loo at night.

THE RIGHT SHOES: Your footwear needs will vary according to what you plan to do; if it's climbing a mountain or trekking after gorillas, waterproof boots with good ankle support are best, while in most cases on a normal safari a pair of trainers or deck shoes is fine. Sandals or flip flops are perfect for wearing while in camp. We strongly advise against taking brand new shoes, so please take time to wear them in before you go.

A PAIR OF BINOCULARS: There might well be several pairs of binoculars in your safari vehicle for all of you to share, but so you don't have to wait for your turn, and to avoid

missing the action, we suggest taking your own. We've given more detail in the dedicated section on [page 12](#), but as a rule you get what you pay for, with more costly models definitely offering superior build and image quality. They vary from £30 to over £1,800 for a pair. It's a good idea to visit a camera retailer or dedicated outdoors pursuit shop and test several makes in your budget range, to give you a chance to choose the ones that work best for you.

TOILETRIES: You will be provided with some essentials like soap, shampoo and body lotion in the majority of the safari camps and hotels we work with. These are usually good quality local products. It's a good idea to bring your own toothbrush and toothpaste, as well as any shaving tackle or conditioners you might need. If you prefer to travel with your own supplies, it's worth decanting some of each into a smaller container, rather than using most of your luggage allowance for heavy bottles of shampoo and soap.

MEDICATION: It depends on where you are travelling, but mostly it's wise to take malaria prophylaxis. We find that our clients rarely get ill on holiday, since most meals are prepared to western hygiene standards, and to recipes that you'll recognize. However, the long flight to get there, the change in climate and altitude, and the travel on bouncy bush roads can upset some people's constitution, and cause occasional 'travellers tummy'. If you are prone to this, it's worth taking something to alleviate it. You should also carry any prescription medicine with you in your hand luggage. It's wise to take a note from your doctor or your prescription with you, just in case you are asked to show it by a customs officer.

INSECT REPELLANT: It's a good idea to avoid being bitten by mosquitoes or bothered by other insects, and DEET or citronella based products work well as repellants. Insect numbers tend to be much lower during the dry season, and greater round permanent water and during the rains.

A DRYBAG OR SIMILAR: Dust and water are the greatest enemies of modern electronic gadgets, with cameras especially vulnerable to dust ingress and subsequent damage. Should you be spending time on a river or lake, and planning to take photos while there, it's a great idea to protect your valuables with a bag that you can seal against the elements. Don't forget that rain happens year round in several parts of Africa, and can come without notice.

SOFT SAFARI HAT WITH A DRAW STRING: Keep the sun off your face and head, and stay dry in the rain. A floppy hat with a large brim is both very practical and versatile, as well as fashionable, so we're told. If you have short hair on your neck it's wise to protect it from burning with a neck flap.

CAMERAS

Having a good quality SLR camera will improve your chances of getting the very best results.



Photographing forest buffalo. 📷 ANDREW HOWARD, WILDERNESS SAFARIS

Most digital cameras these days can take amazingly good pictures with little help from the user; in fact they are verging on being idiot proof. However, if you are an enthusiast it's worth selecting a model which works for your wishes, and also taking the time to learn how to use it well. Having a good quality SLR camera will improve your chances of getting the very best results. A selection of suitable lenses that offer high optical quality is very worthwhile. There are also some excellent point and shoot cameras with built in zooms which can also work well under some circumstances. Thanks to their light weight and reduced size, these can be ideal for walking and riding safaris.

We advise a minimum optical length of 200 mm for taking wildlife pictures, but ideally you'd have something around 300, or even 400 mm. It's usually hard to use anything that isn't hand held, even though bean bags and similar supports are often provided on vehicles. Your gear needs to be maneuverable too, so as to be ready when the action shifts its location. If you like to use a larger lens than 400 mm, please remember that it's really difficult to keep a vehicle stable enough to get the best images.

It's sensible to take at least two memory cards with you, to cover the possibility of a card suffering a technical failure, or excessive zest while taking photos. You can buy inexpensive mobile storage gadgets which are great for storing your images while travelling, as well as reviewing them on the go. These things can be bought with viewing screens and the capacity to edit and remove shots from your library, saving you time when you get home.

All of the camps and lodges we work with provide charging points, either in the rooms or the main mess building, and very often in vehicles as well. We do suggest however, that you take a spare battery, as well as taking every opportunity to use your charger and keep the batteries ready for action. A 12V charger that plugs into a vehicle cigarette lighter is also a useful idea, especially on a mobile safari when you spend less time in camp, and tend to do longer drives. Make sure you have all the equipment you need to connect with whatever source of power you wish to use.

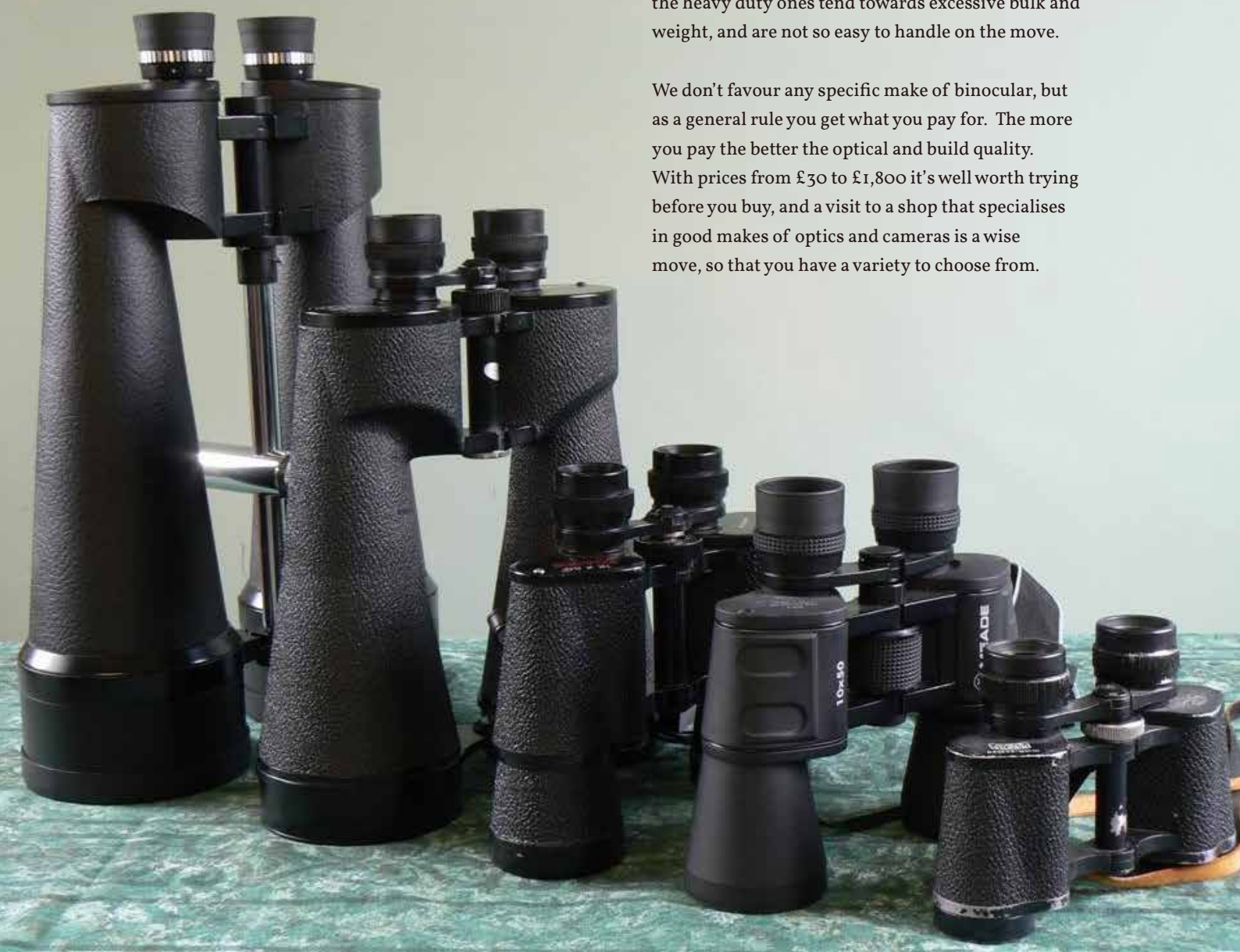
Whether you choose to buy or rent, the right binoculars will ensure comfortable, clear game viewing.  WIKIMEDIA

BINOCULARS

In our experience the specification of binoculars that work best for a safari is either 8 x 40 or 10 x 40. These give an optimum blend of viewing angle and magnification.

While many suppliers offer numerous models and types of binocular, ranging from ultra compact to heavy duty seagoing models, we find that the mid-range models work best in the field: the compact versions can be difficult to keep steady and to see through, while the heavy duty ones tend towards excessive bulk and weight, and are not so easy to handle on the move.

We don't favour any specific make of binocular, but as a general rule you get what you pay for. The more you pay the better the optical and build quality. With prices from £30 to £1,800 it's well worth trying before you buy, and a visit to a shop that specialises in good makes of optics and cameras is a wise move, so that you have a variety to choose from.



LESS IS MORE: LUGGAGE IN AFRICA

We've given you some ideas about what kit to take, but how do you get it to Africa?

A soft sided hold-all is ideal, as you'll probably be flying in a light aircraft at some stage during your holiday; the great majority of our clients do. Due to the size of the craft and the payload limits when flying in the tropics, baggage quantities are strictly limited to ensure the safety of the plane and its passengers. The luggage pods under the aircraft bellies also are a bit small, so it's vital that your luggage is small and flexible enough to be loaded through a small hatch. Luggage limits tend to be between 15 and 20 kg per person, but we will specify this on your itinerary.

Bags with wheels, frames, and hard sides just can't be put into the cargo pods, and are often heavier than the contents. A holdall, while not perhaps the height of fashion, is spot on, carrying sufficient for your holiday, as well as being user friendly for the pilots and ground crew. 120 litres should be an adequate size, and the following retailers have a variety on offer, to suit most needs:

HERE ARE SOME OF OUR FAVORITES:

- [Cotswold Outdoors](#)
- [Millets](#)
- [Go Outdoors](#)

You'll be surprised how little you need to take with you since you can generally get laundry done every day, and it's often back with you by the evening, ironed and tidily folded. Many camps decline to wash ladies underwear for cultural reasons, but there's no need to worry since you will find soap powder provided beside the basin in most camps. Toiletries such as



Leave the hard shell at home.

 PATAGONIA

shampoo, shower gel, conditioner and skin lotion are supplied in the great majority of the camps we work with, not just basic supermarket stuff either, but some quality ecologically friendly African brands. It's a big help as you can leave the heavy bottles at home.

We can arrange additional baggage capacity should you need it, something that's especially valuable for keen photographers with their tripods, extra-large lenses, and multiple camera bodies. It's a good idea to let us know well in advance should you want help with this, so that you don't have to decide between clean clothes and your camera gear.

There's no need to worry about heaving your baggage around between vehicles and aircraft; someone is always on hand to help and to take the load for you.

INSURANCE

In the shadow of 'Big Daddy', Namibia.

📷 DANA ALLEN, WILDERNESS SAFARIS

Comprehensive travel insurance is essential for anyone visiting Africa. It's designed to cover you should you have the misfortune to fall ill, as well as for the unlikely eventuality that you have to cancel your holiday.

Medical evacuation costs can be huge, so it's vital that you have these covered by insurance. Make sure too that whatever activities you plan to take part in, such as riding, climbing Kilimanjaro, or white water rafting, are covered by the policy.

Some insurers know Africa and understand what it entails well, while some do not. We can advise on whom to contact for a policy, but cannot arrange insurance for you.



HEALTH AND VACCINATIONS

Keeping your family fit and healthy on
safari is easy with the right preparation.
📷 AFRICAN HORSEBACK SAFARIS

We've all heard tales of woe from friends or colleagues who've come back from a dream holiday, having been ill, but did you know that more than one million people go on safari every year and have a fabulous trouble free time, and return in glowing good health with fully laden memory cards and some great stories to tell. The greatest causes of illness are dehydration, heat, and the fatigue of international flights. Often people don't drink enough in the heat of Africa, regardless of being reminded to do so.



At Aardvark Safaris we are meticulous about preparing our clients for their travels to Africa, with comprehensive information covering every aspect of their holiday, including health matters, tipping, climate, some language tips, and guidance about how Africa is different from life at home.

You must protect yourselves before travel with vaccinations and also be aware of the risk of malaria. There are some wonderful parts of Africa which are malaria free should you be concerned about the medication aspect. The two primary ways to protect against malaria are:

BITE AVOIDANCE: Since there is no such thing as a 100% effective prophylaxis against malaria, a crucial first line of defence is to avoid being bitten by mosquitos. Keep your legs and arms covered between sunset and sunrise; wear long sleeved shirts, socks and trousers, and avoid dark colours. Make sure your bed is covered with a mosquito net while sleeping.

If you stay in a tent, you've no need of an additional net over your bed since the tents are sealed to prevent insects getting in, and the interior is usually sprayed before you go to bed. This is done while you are having dinner, along with turning down the beds and closing windows, tent flaps, or nets if you are in a room.

It's wise to apply insect repellent to any skin which is not covered by clothing, especially feet, ankles and legs. You should source products of a good standard, the most effective containing 25-35% DEET; those lotions with a higher concentration are no more effective, and due to being so much oilier are less easy to apply. Some people find that products using citronella or eucalyptus oil work just as well as ones that have DEET and can be nicer for the user and your skin. You may find these a suitable alternative, but this is likely to be dependent on the countries in which you plan to travel.

MALARIA PROPHYLAXIS: Malarone, which incorporates the compounds proguanil and atovaquone, is the preferred choice for the majority of people and situations. It must be taken for one day before arrival in a malarial area, and for just a week after leaving it.

A pediatric dose of Malarone is available in the UK and many European countries. Produced specifically for children, the tablets have a neutral tasting coating to mask the usual bitterness of the drug, but they can also be crushed if need be. The advice about usages is exactly the same as for adults.

Please make sure you ask your doctor for an accurate prescription for your children as the dose will be based on their weight.

VACCINATIONS: We advise that you discuss which vaccinations you'll need with your GP. Give yourself plenty of time to have the injections, as some may take some time to become effective, and others cannot be given together. Ideally there will be no less than two weeks between finishing the course of vaccinations and departure to Africa.

Here's a list of vaccination that are widely recommended:

- Polio
- Tetanus
- Diphtheria
- Typhoid
- Hepatitis A

YELLOW FEVER is a virus that's carried by mosquitoes which are active by day. Countries in which it is endemic include Kenya, Rwanda, Uganda and Congo. On arrival into these countries, apart from Kenya, you will have to show a current yellow fever vaccination certificate. When arriving from a country where the disease exists you will also need to provide the certificate. If you arrive somewhere that is free of yellow fever from a country where it is present (Kenya, Rwanda, Uganda or Congo), you will have to provide your yellow fever certificate at the port of entry.

You will need to obtain up to date advice on the current health regulations at the time of travel. Clients travelling with Aardvark Safaris will find details in their pre-departure information.

WHAT HAPPENS IF I HATE INJECTIONS AND DON'T WANT TO TAKE MALARIA PROPHYLAXIS? There are some fantastic malaria free safari regions in Africa, and we can arrange wonderful itineraries for any who prefer to avoid drugs and vaccinations. Some people are advised to avoid live vaccinations, and in this case you can ask your doctor for medical certificate to detail the reasons for not having the injection. Ideally, an accompanying letter from the doctor will also provide travel dates, and an explanation of the decision not to be vaccinated.

RESPONSIBLE TOURISM AND SUSTAINABLE TRAVEL

We love Africa and everything about it, the spectacular scenery, the magnificent wildlife, the wonderful people and their vibrant and varied cultures..

We love the continent so much that we've dedicated ourselves to its preservation in every small way we can. Aardvark Safaris got involved with African tourism for this reason and it's why we're huge advocates of responsible and sustainable travel. What does that actually mean? How can a visitor help?

- Choose lodge operators and guides who understand that the sensitive interaction with their environment is crucial to their livelihood and the future of their businesses. Many camps and lodges are engaged with their local communities as well, encouraging people to cherish their surroundings and the flora and fauna. Your visit also contributes funds which go into health, education and water provision in these communities.
- If you are interested, ask if it's possible to meet conservationists and visit community projects while on safari. Seeing how park fees support anti-poaching patrols, for example, is a great way to understand how tourism is helping to protect endangered species.
- Find out if the specialist you have chosen informs its clients, and educates its team, about responsible travel, giving specific guidance for whichever destination they are visiting. At Aardvark Safaris, we've been given awards by the Association of Independent Tour Operators for our commitment to ethical travel.
- Select a company with a track record of supporting African charities. Aardvark are proud supporters of the Koiyaki Guide School in Kenya's Masai Mara and have sponsored local students who become the conservationists and park rangers of the future, and the guardians of the ecosystems that we love so much. We're also supporters of the Tusk Trust and Tusk USA.

Ethical travel is a way of life. At Aardvark Safaris, we're dedicated to continuing the education and sponsorship that protects fragile and vital environments. We're proud of our many past clients who have sponsored, donated and volunteered. We hope you will, too.



Aardvark Safaris visit Koiyaki Guide School in Kenya.

Buffalo herd, Busanga Plains. © DANA ALLEN, WILDERNESS SAFARIS



part 2



SAFARI



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SAFARI TYPES

Experience the freedom of flying over the
vast Sossusvlei Dunes, Namibia.
📷 DANA ALLEN, WILDERNESS SAFARIS

There is a widespread mental image of a tough off-road vehicle crossing vast expanses of open country through herds of wildlife, giving the occupants a safe and comfortable introduction to Africa's prolific natural wealth. Don't think that this is the only way to immerse yourself in Africa and its wilderness. There are myriad options on offer these days.





Home comforts in the wild on small group and private mobile safaris in Botswana's Okavango Delta.

📷 UNCHARTED AFRICA



Inside a mobile safari tent. 📷 NORMAN CARR

MOBILE SAFARIS

The original safari from the romantic age of exploring the continent. [Mobile safaris](#) give you access to some of the most remote and least developed habitat, as well as the flexibility to do as you wish, go where you want, and stay as long as it suits with each sighting. The guides who lead these safaris tend to be among the very best, are adept at hosting and camp management as well as incredibly knowledgeable about the habitats and wildlife you will encounter.

OUR TOP MOBILE SAFARIS:

- [Canoe safaris on the Zambezi River](#)
- [Mobile riding safaris](#)
- [Exploring Botswana's Okavango Delta](#)



WALKING SAFARIS

Although you won't get quite as close, travel as far, or see as many animals, [walking safaris](#) are intense, thrilling and fascinating. Walking with an expert guide, such as those Aardvark Safaris chooses to work with, allows you to hear, smell, touch, and see every detail of Africa. It enlivens the senses, and you also see the very small things that are invisible from a vehicle.

Many safari camps offer part or full day walks. If you are more adventurous you can spend several days out in the bush, walking between camps, or even having the camp move with you. Experienced guides can teach you a plethora of bush survival skills, and bring every little thing to life. You might also see Africa's more dangerous beasts but you won't get too close for comfort – Aardvark's own Francis, Charlie and Tracy were no more than 30 feet from a pride of lion gorging themselves on a zebra on a recent trip to Zambia.

The food on a walking safari can be one of the biggest surprises; how on earth do the chefs conjure up such culinary miracles on an open fire? You won't have to help with the camp, and it will generally reappear like magic in the new camp site each day. You'll be surprised by the level



Multi-day camel-assisted treks in Kenya. 📷 KARISIA SAFARIS

of comfort too, with lovely linen, decent beds, hot water, a bar with chilled drinks, and of course the amazing food.

OUR TOP WALKING SAFARIS:

- [Multi-day, camel-assisted treks](#) in Kenya
- [Full-day walking safaris](#) in Zambia's South Luangwa National Park
- Walking with the Kalahari Bushmen in Botswana's Makgadikgadi Pans
- A multi-day walking safari in Tanzania's vast Ruaha National Park
- Walking in Zimbabwe's Hwange National Park with Africa's top guides

RIDING SAFARIS:

As a unique way to experience Africa and its wildlife, riding with herds of game is exhilarating. On a horse you are as close to being part of the bush as you'll ever be, and are dependent on your steed and its senses and instincts. Horses are brilliant off road vehicles, literally able to go anywhere, and at significant speed too. The truth is that [riding alongside wildlife](#), or tracking elephant and buffalo from a horse is one of the most exciting things you can do. There are also plenty of lodges where equestrian sports such as polo or cross country jumping are on offer, as well as wildlife viewing.

With numerous options for itineraries and accommodation, there's a riding safari to suit any keen equestrian. Mobile camping safaris across the Masai Mara or the Makgadikgadi Pans, lodge based riding in Kenya's Laikipia, South Africa and Botswana, and exploring

Namibia's deserts and sleeping under the stars are a few of the choices. Several lodges offer part day rides, in addition to walks, game drives, and other activities which are great options if you are travelling with non-riders.

Numerous good operators run riding safaris in Africa and we have tested them all. We know the specific strengths of different rides and will recommend riding safari that best suits you. We make all the arrangements to guarantee your holiday is relaxing.

OUR TOP RIDING SAFARIS:

- [Follow the wildebeest migration on a mobile safari in Kenya](#)
- [Incredible wildlife viewing in Botswana](#)
- [Eight top tips on riding safari planning](#)

Cheek-by-jowl with wildlife on an exhilarating horseback riding safari in Botswana. 📷 AFRICAN HORSEBACK SAFARIS





See game from a whole new perspective on the Savuti Channel, Botswana. 📷 DANA ALLEN, WILDERNESS SAFARIS



A traditional dugout canoe in the Okavango Delta.

📷 CAMP OKAVANGO

CANOEING SAFARIS

Africa's massive rivers are the lifeblood of the continent's incredible biodiversity, and from the river banks you can often see more species in one place than almost anywhere else. A [canoe safari](#) is one of the most exciting journeys possible, opening up a private wilderness and a new way of seeing the world.

The mighty Zambezi River is the epitome of an excellent river for a safari. Forming the border of Zambia and Zimbabwe it flows through Mana Pools National Park, bringing life to a wealth of birds, hippo, elephant, and predators. Canoe trips always travel with the current to reduce the paddling needed, but it's still good exercise. Multi day trips are wonderful for completely escaping the normal world, with no sounds bar that of water lapping against your vessel, and the occasional slap of a paddle on the water. A rewarding, challenging, exhilarating adventure; you'll remember it forever.

OUR TOP CANOE SAFARI IN AFRICA:

- [A multi-day camping canoe safari](#) in Zimbabwe's gorgeous Mana Pools National Park

Pit yourself against Mount Kenya on a multi-day trek. 📍 SUMMITS AFRICA



CLIMBING AND TREKKING SAFARIS

Africa has numerous fabled mountains and many majestic ranges whose names conjure up romantic images. Kilimanjaro, Mt Kenya, Mt Meru and the Rwenzoris are among the best known and most accessible of them, and can be hiked for one day or climbed in their entirety. Some peaks are at high altitude, and must be approached with great care, while others can be tackled safely in a day.

There are choices to suit casual walkers as well as serious climbers and hikers. Stunningly beautiful as well as very remote, the continent's mountains are also hot spots of ecological interest, with altitude variations offering ever changing vegetation and micro-climates, as well as unique wildlife adapted to its surroundings.

When scaling the highest peaks, it's imperative to travel with experts who have unparalleled knowledge and the

right gear to keep you safe and allow you to enjoy the ascent. Mountain climbs are guided by highly experienced guides with certified first-aid training, a naturalist's knowledge of the land, and a lecturer's knowledge of the geography. Climbing an African peak is awesome.

Long distance hikes, day climbs and walks, expeditions into remote ranges, carefully planned ascents of the continent's greatest mountains, there is much choice in several countries, including Kenya, Tanzania, Uganda, Rwanda, Malawi and South Africa.

OUR TOP TREKS IN AFRICA

- [Climb Mount Kilimanjaro to the roof of Africa](#)
- [Explore a wide range of hikes and treks in Africa's great wilderness regions](#)



When you buy gorilla permits and visit other primates your money is channeled directly towards preserving their future. 📍 VICTORIA LANGMEAD

PRIMATE SAFARIS:

Nobody ever forgets the first time they meet a [mountain gorilla](#) face to face in Rwanda or Uganda. The world's largest primate is massively powerful yet amazingly gentle and caring, and remarkably we share more than 97% of our DNA with them. Even clients who have seen every country, and enough lions to last a lifetime, tell us that this is the best, most memorable adventure of all their African travels.

Chimpanzees, lemurs, monkeys and baboons are highly intelligent, and with their complex interactions, communication, mobility, and intelligence are fascinating personalities and mighty rewarding to spend time with. Western Tanzania and Uganda are the best places to see chimpanzees, where research and habituation programmes have been under way for many years. Anthropologists such as Jane Goodall have made a name for themselves studying these enthralling animals.

OUR TOP PRIMATE SAFARIS

- [Find out about 'a day in the life of mountain gorillas'](#)
- [How to plan a gorilla track in Rwanda](#)

Don't forget that you can include a primate safari in a longer trip combining with other safari areas, the beach, or even scaling a mighty mountain summit. Please just ask us for ideas that fit in with your dates and plans.

FAMILY SAFARIS

Aardvark Safaris pioneered family safaris, encouraging tented camps and safari lodges to build family friendly rooms, and to recruit guides with a natural affinity for children.



Drum beating at Little Kulala, Namibia.

OLWEN EVANS, WILDERNESS SAFARIS.



Choose from a vast range of fun family-friendly accommodations like the family tent at Duma Tau.

📷 DANA ALLEN, WILDERNESS SAFARIS

Most of our sales staff and all of our directors have taken their children to Africa on their own holidays. We look for camps and lodges whose owners have raised their children in the bush, and have an instinct for working with families. We most like the ones that encourage kids to have fun, doing all sorts of things that they can't do at home. We know just how special Africa is when seen through little eyes.

Adventures never end; whether it's a game drive, a meal in the bush under a tree or the stars, horse or camel rides, swimming and tubing in rivers, fishing, archery, meeting the local people, insect hunts, poo analysis, walks, bike rides, night drives, starlit sleep outs, the list is huge. Spontaneity and flexibility are the keys, being able to respond to the moment and make the very most of it.

Your accommodation makes a big difference to a safari, and we like to offer variety to families, so they

can enjoy the luxury of a lodge as well as the thrill of sleeping under canvas. We also like offering families their own private piece of Africa, whether in tents or a private bush home. For many, the beaches of the Indian Ocean are too tempting to resist, and provide the perfect place to relax before heading home.

- Game tracking
- Night drives
- Bird watching
- Horse and camel riding safaris
- Whitewater rafting
- Canoe and boat safaris
- Camping out in the African bush
- Sleep outs under the stars
- Fishing
- Mountain biking
- Meeting local people
- Star gazing
- Swimming in pools, rivers and a warm ocean
- Snorkeling and diving on colourful coral reef

Re-live the romance and spirit of the golden age of safari.
Zarafa Dhow Suites, Botswana. 📍 GREAT PLAINS CONSERVATION





— ACCOMMODATION

Safari Accommodation in Africa offers diversity to match that of its amazing scenery, and your choices will be related to the locations you choose to visit and your budget.

To provide variety and interest, we do our best to include a range of accommodation, often tents as well as cottages, to provide the luxury of a lodge combined with the adventure and romance of sleeping under canvas. Whatever style of accommodation we suggest, which could be a basic tent or something like a stately home, all share some key features which afford real luxury in the remotest bush locations; great food, en-suite bathrooms, fine linens, friendly, attentive staff and hosts, beautiful locations, and great service from skillful staff and guides. Attention to detail is what we look for, whether having good coffee at sunrise or a plentiful supply of ice for sundowners.

We don't own or invest in any properties in Africa; Aardvark Safaris is completely independent and has chosen to work with a carefully chosen portfolio of lodges and camps to suit all budgets and styles. We visit Africa regularly and can correctly state that we have stayed in the camps, tested the beds and bathrooms, enjoyed the food and hospitality, approved the guiding, and checked out each property's USPs; when we give a recommendation you can be confident that it is tried and trusted to do exactly what it says on the tin.

HOTELS:

There are plenty of city hotels to choose from and we prefer to work with the best in every city. Whether you need a night conveniently close to an airport, for example in Nairobi or Johannesburg, or a week of luxury in Cape Town, or a simple guesthouse in the Cape Winelands, we'll give you options for different levels of quality and cost.



One of Cape Town's finest boutique hotels, Ellerman House is the epitome of luxury with its plush bedrooms, fine art collection and sweeping views across the Atlantic Ocean and Robben Island.

📍 ELLERMAN HOUSE



SAFARI LODGES:

Lodges are more solid, consisting of buildings made of timber or stone, and tiled, thatched or shingled roofs. Many lodge cottages can be opened wide to let Africa in, while others have fixed glazing, or insect mesh where the glass might have been. Air-conditioning, fireplaces, and mini-bars help cope with climatic extremes, while the lodge itself might also have a lounge, bar, dining room and, often, a swimming pool.



It's not every day you get to feed resident giraffes through the second floor window of a historic lodge. Giraffe Manor, Kenya.

📷 THE SAFARI COLLECTION

TENTED CAMPS:

The tents in African safari camps are more than a little different from the ones you might have used in the UK. As much as anything, they are huge, and include some lovely pieces of furniture, attractive artworks and decorations. The great majority have en-suite bathrooms featuring flush loos, double basins, hot and cold water, either on demand or running. Some of the showers may be in the form of a bucket or safari shower, which comprises five gallons of hot water released through a rose by a chain. While meals are eaten outside as often as is practical, these camps have very comfortable lounges and bars, and a dining room for occasions when the conditions outside are inclement. Safari camps tend to be very sociable, and the communal parts are good places to meet fellow guests and discuss experiences. Some camps have a pool for hot weather. Luxury levels vary from minimal to outrageous, and you really should stay in at least one tented camp on your safari.

Safari tents are perfectly safe, and though animals are free to wander through camp, they don't like people and won't try to get into your tent. There are guards on duty at all times and should you feel concerned, you always have something with which to call for help. These gadgets rarely see any use, and should not be used for requesting drinks during siesta time.

MOBILE TENTED CAMPS:

For the more adventurous, getting even closer to nature or following migrating wildlife is the ideal holiday, and for this a mobile safari camp is just perfect. Light of weight and footprint, the camp can be moved in a day, and set up in a new, private, remote, exclusive location ready for sundowners and a shower. Hot water is provided by camp fire, showers are of the bucket variety, loos can be short or long drop, or even flushing. You sacrifice surprisingly little in creature comforts, but you gain greatly in exclusivity and personal service.



BEACH PROPERTIES:

From simple guest houses to magnificent private islands and large sophisticated resorts, there's a bewildering amount of choice. Different properties suit different needs, with some being ideal for families, others for couples, and yet others for singles. The key factor is that many claim to offer more than they do in reality, and Aardvark's first-hand experience is crucial to make sure you invest your budget wisely in the property that offers just the combination of luxury, space, outlook and activities that you want.

Barefoot luxury at an idyllic
beach property in the
Seychelles.

 BANYAN TREE



PRIVATE SAFARI HOUSES:

These exclusive-use bush houses are fully serviced and staffed, and perfect for families or groups of friends. Offering a self-contained unit with its own guide, a house can be surprisingly cost effective as well. Many are beautifully located in wildlife hotspots too, and provide remarkably good game viewing without leaving the environs of the house.

(top to bottom)

View from Chongwe River House
down to the Zambezi River.

The lounge at Tswalu Tarkuni.

Twin bedroom at Tswalu Tarkuni.



FOOD AND DRINK ON SAFARI

The great majority of people on safari are really surprised by the quality of food in safari camps, even in the most remote of places. Largely catering to suit their guests' demographics, the food offered by these amazing chefs tends to be familiar to the western constitution, and truly superb in flavour, presentation and preparation. Many people expect to lose some weight in Africa, but most come home with a belt that's tighter than when they left.

Candlelit communal dining African safari style.

📍 MADIKWE SAFARI LODGE



- **BREAKFAST** could include fresh fruits, familiar cereals, locally made yogurts, bread fresh from the oven, bacon and sausages, eggs cooked to order, or all of the above. There's always a plentiful supply of coffee, tea, fruit juice and water.
- **LUNCH** often features salad, usually sourced from the camp or lodge's own garden, cheeses, quiche, or cold meat such as ham or salami. Fruit and vegetables are always carefully washed in clean safe water. There's often fruit or ice cream for dessert.
- **AFTERNOON TEA** is an African safari tradition, and could well include canapés or something savoury, but cake is most likely to appear every time, to help you through the few hours of game driving before dinner is ready.
- **DINNER** generally comprises three courses (and on occasion up to seven), with a starter, main course of meat or fish with vegetables, and a dessert. There's often a cheese board to round things off nicely as well.
- **DRINKS** (apart from premium brands) are included while on safari, and the itinerary sets out just what's included at each property. Maintaining fluid levels in the heat of Africa is vital, and we urge you to drink plenty of water. The hosts in each camp will brief you about the property when you first arrive, and this will include information about the provision of safe drinking water.
- **SPECIAL DIETARY REQUIREMENTS OF ALL SORTS** can be accommodated easily as long as the camp has sufficient notice. Remember that the chef cannot pop out to the supermarket when you arrive. Vegan, allergies, food sensitivity, halal or kosher, gluten intolerance or merely a preference, whatever it is, let us know well in advance and we'll guarantee that you'll be fed superbly.
- **CHILDREN** are welcomed in many safari kitchens, and can help prepare salads or bake cakes. Child-friendly food can be produced at a moment's notice, should it be requested.
- **COMMUNAL DINING** is hosted by the camp manager or a senior guide, providing a house party atmosphere with a lot of laughter and chat around one big table. Being sociable places, most tented safari camps, whether permanent or mobile, offer this dining experience.
- **SHARED HOSTED MEALS** are part of the scene in some permanent safari lodges as well, while others give you a private table, to which you may invite new friends. The majority of beach properties arrange private dining, although there's nothing to stop guests joining up to make bigger parties.

— YOUR GUIDE

Masai guide and guest paint snow-capped
Kilimanjaro. 📷 BEVERLY JOUBERT

A great guide is vital for enjoying Africa to the full. Aardvark Safaris know most of the best guides in Africa and we sponsor many younger ones through guide school too. We do our best to make sure we only work with Africa's finest.





Truly great guides are multi-faceted people with highly developed skills of observation, communication, and acute and astute intelligence in understanding people. They will naturally be able to reel off the names of everything you see, mimic bird calls, predict where the leopard will be sleeping, know when the dogs are denning, and find lions hunting, but they will also know just when to talk and, more importantly, when to say nothing and let Africa speak for itself.

They are often terrific company at a dinner table, and have years of good stories to tell. The best of them take their professional career very seriously, and will quite likely become well known around the world. 9 features of a superb guide:

- **EAGLE EYES:** The ability to spot animals and birds almost hidden in the bush
- **EXPERIENCE:** Becoming wise in the ways of the world, its diverse people and the African bush takes many years of work and study
- **PATIENCE:** Good things come to those who wait; animals do things at their own pace, when they feel like it and not at a speed to suit us. Waiting for action is good.
- **ENTHUSIASM:** The African bush is a thrilling place, and a good guide makes your safari fun too
- **CONVERSATION:** Being comfortable with people of all ages and backgrounds
- **PASSION:** No two days are the same, and the best guides see or learn something new on every game drive or walk. They are always engaged by what's going on around them
- **CULTURAL UNDERSTANDING:** The skill of being able to make things relevant to all guests, wherever they are from and whatever their beliefs
- **SAFETY FIRST:** An instinctive feel for situations, and knowing what to do in a tight spot to keep everyone safe and the wildlife undisturbed
- **ENTERTAINING:** Africa is fun; great guides keep you amused and entertained as well as supremely well informed

Giraffe mother and calf at Little Tubu Camp, Botswana.

📷 DANA ALLEN, WILDERNESS SAFARIS





WHERE THE WILD THINGS ARE

*Even though the Lion King was set here,
Africa is not Disneyland in any way.*

What you see will depend on the seasons, and some parts of the continent are simply inaccessible for some of the year due to the weather. Climate, landscape, and altitude all have a part to play in determining the available resources for any species, and social habits (mating, migrations, and so on) are often based around these factors. To get the best out of a trip it's best to ask us for advice about [when to visit](#).

You are very likely to come across the expression 'Big 5' when reading about animals you might find in safari. This was a phrase coined by hunters to describe the group of animals considered the most dangerous to track and hunt on foot. These days, the term is used to refer to some of Africa's most iconic wildlife: lion, leopard, elephant, rhino and buffalo.



LEOPARD

Solitary and shy, leopard are very well camouflaged and amazingly good at hiding. They often lose kills to hyena and lion, which are more powerful and social, so tend to hunt at night, and take their prey up trees if possible. Just seeing a leopard is a thrill, and watching one hunt is an amazing privilege as well as a lesson in patience. We know where best to see leopard, Zambia, for example, on a night drive in a national park, and while wildlife sightings cannot be guaranteed, you have a great chance of being in the right spot when needed with Aardvark Safaris' guidance.

Nothing equals the piercing gaze of the leopard,
Vumbura Plains, Botswana.

📷 DANA ALLEN, WILDERNESS SAFARIS



ELEPHANT

With their tender and complex social interactions, elephants are fascinating. Watching mothers chiding their errant calves, teenagers playing, and ancient and wise matriarchs leading herds is enchanting. Elephants are not generally hard to find, as their movements are governed by water, making them reasonably predictable. They can be seen wading through Botswana's watery wonderland, congregating on both banks of the Zambezi River, gathered around waterholes in Hwange National Park, wallowing in the red mud of the Samburu National Park in Kenya, and digging for water in Namibia's deserts. Botswana's Chobe National Park boasts the highest concentration of elephants in Africa while Maputo Elephant Sanctuary in Mozambique claims to have the continent's biggest tuskers.

If you're truly passionate about pachyderms, then [Elephant Watch](#), where Iain Douglas Hamilton—founder of Save the Elephants—has done decades of research, could be the ideal safari camp for you. The Sheldrick Wildlife Trust in Nairobi is a wonderful place to spend an afternoon, and you can meet orphaned elephants and maybe sponsor one too.

CHEETAH

Cheetah can attain incredible speeds of up to 120 kph, although not for long. They are built for speed and nothing else, and they need plenty of space to make the most of their spectacular acceleration and to chase prey. Cheetah can be found year-round in dry areas of Botswana's Okavango Delta, the open plains and savannah of the Masai Mara and the Serengeti, and the flat salt pans of Etosha National Park. Cheetah are best seen in the dry season when the grass is short enough to reveal their ground hugging shapes.

Cheetah cubs. 📷 RUSSELL FRIEDMAN



Wildebeest as far as the eye can see
from Mara Plains Camp, Kenya.
📷 BEVERLY JOUBERT

THE WILDEBEEST MIGRATION

Best known for its truly epic annual migration, an annual gyration of millions of these wonderful antelope travelling in search of better food and water resources, the wildebeest looks as if it has been cobbled together from the leftover bits of other animals. This spectacular congregation is one of the natural wonders of our world, a must-see for anyone with a passion for Africa. Thanks to the sheer size of the ecosystem, several times of year give excellent sightings; January to March in the southern Serengeti for the calving season, and July to October in the northern Serengeti and the Masai Mara. With so much meat on the move, the territorial predators do their best to harvest as much as possible during a brief window of opportunity, leading to some exciting interactions.

It's too good to miss if you love wildlife — please call us for a more detailed chat with one of our wildebeest migration experts.



RHINO

Rhino and calf in Kenya.

THE SAFARI COLLECTION

Tragically, rhino have been massacred by poachers in most of their habitat. They don't move with the seasons, and few places are now well enough protected for them to thrive. They can be found in a few isolated spots and some of the best are the Lewa Wildlife Conservancy and Ol Pejeta Conservancy in Kenya, Desert Rhino Camp in Namibia, the Ngorongoro Crater in Tanzania, the Sabi Sands Reserve in South Africa's Kruger National Park, Tswalu in the South African Kalahari, and Etosha National Park in Namibia.

We have good contacts in the conservation world, and can arrange for you to assist on anti-poaching duties or with conservation tasks.



CAPE BUFFALO

Renowned for being grumpy, Cape buffalo live in 1,000 strong herds, which trail dust clouds in their wake as they roam the plains. As many as 4,000 of them gather in Uganda's Kidepo Valley National Park at certain times of year. The great majority of our favourite safari regions have abundant buffalo, and usually numerous lion too. The excitement provided by the interaction between these ancient adversaries is second to none – endless battles at Duba Plains in the Okavango Delta, grumpy old males wallowing in the waters of Uganda's Kazinga Channel, wandering herds being tracked through Hwange and South Luangwa National Parks by hungry prides with numerous cubs to feed and with countless colorful oxpecker birds in tow. As much as lion favour the buffalo, so do tsetse flies, and clouds of these horrible insects can make game viewing a little uncomfortable.



Buffalo and egret. 📷 JOY'S CAMP



Force of nature: Cape buffalo herd on the move.

📷 AFRICAN HORSEBACK SAFARIS



It's not easy being king: young male lions on the cusp of adulthood. 📷 ASILIA LODGES

LION

The sad truth is that, despite being the King of Beasts and synonymous with Africa, lion are under severe threat from habitat loss. At the moment Namibia has the sole growing population. Lion can be seen year round in many of Africa's best known reserves, where they are well protected but have limited space. However, should you visit one of these sanctuaries, you will be contributing directly to one or more of the vital conservation programmes that are working to protect this iconic species for the benefit of future generations. Large prides can be found in Kenya's Masai Mara, Tanzania's Serengeti, the Kruger National Park and surrounding private reserves in South Africa, Zambia's South Luangwa and Lower Zambezi national parks, Hwange National Park in Zimbabwe, Namibia's Etosha National Park, and Botswana's Okavango Delta, Selinda and Linyanti Reserves.

Due to their decreasing numbers in many of these areas, the lions are known so well to the guides that they'll probably be able to share their life stories with you!



Lioness and cubs share a tender moment, Etosha National Park, Namibia.

📷 DANA ALLEN, WILDERNESS SAFARIS





Eco-tourism has been pivotal in making gorilla conservation a triumph.

📍 SABYINYO SILVERBACK LODGE, VOLCANOES NATIONAL PARK, RWANDA

MOUNTAIN GORILLA

Not far from the equator in [Uganda](#) and [Rwanda](#), a range of hills and a chain of magnificent volcanoes pierce the clouds, and on their forest clad slopes you might find the fabled “Gorillas in the Mist”, the sole surviving population of about 800 mountain gorillas. Since the climate is not extreme at any time, tracking can take place year round, but it’s better to avoid the wetter months of April and May, and November.

The survival of these spectacular primates is a wonderful and all too rare conservation success story. The gorillas have come back from the very edge of extinction thanks to the efforts of some visionary eco-tourism pioneers. All visitors who track gorillas contribute direct to their survival and conservation. We can also arrange time with the vets and conservationists who work tirelessly on their behalf.

Wild dog are clever and successful hunters.

📷 LETAKA SAFARIS

WILD DOG

These are making a comeback too. While they might look like rescue home mongrels, they are highly intelligent, simply brilliant hunters, and remarkably good parents. Also known as “painted dogs,” they have a wonderfully complex social structure, and are very engaging to watch. Populations have made strong recoveries throughout Botswana’s Okavango Delta, Linyanti and Selinda region and Makgadikgadi Pans; in Kenya’s Samburu and Laikipia regions; in Zimbabwe’s Hwange National Park and in Zambia’s South Luangwa National Park. You’ll also find them in the Kruger region and Madikwe Game Reserve in South Africa.



— SAFARI ETIQUETTE AND SAFETY

Seeing spots on a game drive
at Little Vumbura, Botswana.
📷 WILDERNESS SAFARIS

Please don't forget that when in Africa you are in the animals' home territory, not Longleat. You will receive a comprehensive briefing about safety in the bush and around the camp before you are taken on a safari of any sort. Your guide will likely get you closer to the wildlife than you might imagine possible, and it's exhilarating doing so. You won't lack photographic opportunities for sure.



Your guide is crucial to your enjoyment of Africa. As well as becoming your friends, and a massive source of fascinating knowledge, they are also your eyes and ears in the bush, spotting things that ordinary mortals miss. While most of them seem incredibly relaxed, they are always alert to everything that's happening around them, intuitively switched in to sounds, smells, animal body language, and the relationships between species. Because they are so good at what they do they can make it look easy, but never assume that this is the case; they will try to find whatever you ask them for, keep you safe while doing so, and make it all fun too.

During game drives it's wise to stay in your seat all the times, and keep all of your body parts inside the vehicle. The intention is to allow wildlife to feel relaxed around a vehicle, and not to move away at its approach. You can help by not making sudden moves or noises, and not altering the outline of the car. Many guides are keen photographers too, and they are experts at both getting close to the animals and into the best position for pictures.

Quiet talking is ok, and the guide needs to talk or he can't tell you about the beasties, birds, bones and tracks you are seeing. The key is to keep it quiet and calm, which he will do at all times.

Don't forget that bush roads are often rough and bumpy, another good reason to stay in your seat. If you have a bad back or a neck problem, please let us know, and also tell your guide. The vehicles are specially adapted 4x4s, cleverly designed and built to give passengers great unobstructed views of Africa's prolific wildlife. They often have electric points for battery charging, a mini-fridge, and usually reference books as well. Some also have stowage for camera kit, but as a rule it's a really good idea to hold on to your valuables while being driven along.

You might be surprised by how often you'll be allowed out of the car, but never get out unless your guide says you can. There are times such as sundowner drinks, entering a photographic hide, looking at animal tracks, checking out a specific tree, or even a loo stop, when the guide will check the locality, and say yay or nay to getting out. Even though the vehicle's sides are open it still offers much better protection than being on foot. Don't forget that the cuddly sleeping lion in your viewfinder is still wild.

IF YOU ARE EXPLORING ON FOOT

Walking through Africa's wilderness is exhilarating. It's even more important that you listen to your guide and do exactly as he says, since there will often be lion, buffalo, elephant, or other big game nearby. Keep together with the group, and do not wander off. Walking safari guides are among the best qualified and most experienced of all. They always carry a loaded rifle, but deeply resent ever having to use it. They will do all they can to avoid alarming the wildlife, by keeping downwind, moving slowly, being dressed appropriately, and keeping noise under control. The aim is to allow you to see the animals without disturbing them.

Stay away from open water; you won't be able to spot a lurking croc, and hippos are very territorial, and dislike anything encroaching on their space. As with all other species, if they feel threatened they attack as a form of defence. However, if your guide says you may swim it will be fine to do so.

WHEN IN CAMP

Baboons and monkeys are great fun to watch, but remember that they are incorrigible thieves, and very observant too. Never take food inside your tent. They happily snatch sunglasses, and while the results are never especially artistic, they also like playing with cameras. Keep your tent or room closed at all times, unless you are present during daylight hours.

You will always be escorted by a guard at night, and first thing in the morning your guide or one of the camp staff will fetch you for the game drive. Fences are thankfully rare in the best wildlife areas, and there is often wildlife around. Perhaps surprisingly, elephant and buffalo are often found hanging around the edges of camps and sometimes between the rooms too. Beware!

Make good use of the safe in your camp; there might be one in your room, and if not there will be one at the reception or in the manager's office. Africans are as honest as any people, but it's still best not to offer temptation. Don't take your best jewellery and expensive watches,

GIVING BACK ON SAFARI

Africa changes people, and opens their eyes to another world. First timers and repeat clients alike ask how they can help the wildlife they've seen and people they've met.



Almost all of the safari lodges we work with are heavily involved with their local communities, funding things such as schools, conservation education, tree-planting initiatives, HIV/AIDS prevention, burn clinics, women's micro-finance projects and textile workshops. Many safari camps lease their land from local people, giving them significant and stable income, and encouraging the conservation of the wildlife that you travel so far to see.

Your visit to Africa makes a big contribution; conservation fees are levied by every safari camp to help with the cost of protecting habitat and wildlife. If you do want to help more, we have plenty of ideas.

IDEAS TO GIVE BACK ON SAFARI

- **PACK FOR PURPOSE WORKS WITH MANY OF OUR FAVOURITE PROPERTIES.** You can easily learn about the needs of the local people, and bring vitally important supplies with you. For example, two kilos of luggage could amount to 400 pencils, or a stethoscope, blood pressure cuff and 500 plasters.
- **CLIMB A MOUNTAIN FOR A CAUSE.** Several of the Aardvark Safaris sales team have scaled Mount Kilimanjaro and raised money for various charity projects in Africa. It's a great way to get motivated to take on the challenge.
- **CONSIDER VOLUNTOURISM.** Your expertise and skills will be of help to Africa whether working in a school, a medical facility or a training program, even if it's just a short time. Children can do it too.
- **TAKE ON A CYCLE CHALLENGE.** Aardvark co-founder John Spence raced Kenya's 10 to 4 Mountain Bike Challenge a few years back. Starting 10,000 feet up on the northern slopes of Mount Kenya, he cycled some 40 miles down rough tracks to Il Ngwesi at 4,000 feet. Funds raised supported teachers' salaries at the Koiyaki Guiding School.
- **DONATE LIVESTOCK.** [Heifer International](#) can purchase a [cow](#) or [goat](#) on your behalf and give it to a needy family who will benefit daily from the milk.
- **IF YOU'RE PART OF A SERVICE ORGANISATION,** encourage your fellow members to join in, and with your enthusiasm leading the way, you can magnify results.
- **SPONSOR AN ENDANGERED SPECIES.** Spend a few days on a dedicated conservation safari in addition to your main itinerary.
- **SPONSOR A CHILD.** Education is usually free in Africa but school uniforms and supplies aren't. Families often have to choose one of their children to send to school due to meager resources. You can make an enormous difference by providing funds.
- **ASK US HOW YOU CAN HELP.** A school here collected hundreds of unwanted bras and we shipped them off to Project Luangwa in Zambia for them. Read more [here](#). Ask us to include a cultural element in your trip so you can visit some community projects or schools to see which ones you might want to support.

We know you have the best intentions, but here are some things NOT to do:

- Don't bring sweets to hand out to kids or in villages; most have no access to dental care, or even a toothbrush.
- If you're bringing supplies, like a wall map, footballs, or school supplies, please hand them direct to the head or a teacher who can distribute among the children.
- Don't give money; it might be tempting but you don't know where it will go.
- Don't despair. You may not be able to end poverty on your own, but all great movements are made up of individual actions.

The ultimate in barefoot luxury at Benguerra Island.

📷 &BEYOND



part 3



SUMMARY



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TOP TIPS BEFORE YOU GO

- **KEEP AN OPEN MIND.** You'll probably have a list of animals and places you want to see and activities you'd like to do. A specialist operator like Aardvark Safaris may surprise you with an idea you haven't considered. Trust us — we'll often conjure up something unusual but just perfect.
- **CONSIDER TRAVELLING IN THE LOW SEASON.** Africa is a huge continent and has different seasons in different areas. There's somewhere on the continent with great wildlife and good weather year round. Low season months might only be lower season because they're not the major travel times for people from the UK or Europe. The rain doesn't fall all day during the rainy season, and it cleans the air for photographers, animals give birth to young, the landscapes become lush, the skies are dramatic, and prices are much lower.
- **QUESTION THE CHEAPEST OPTION.** A safari is often a once in a lifetime experience so avoid cutting corners. Lower prices often come with more people in a vehicle, long drives instead of flights between locations, bigger lodges which don't suit their surroundings, less flexibility with activities, larger extras bills, and guides who spend their time angling for a tip. A good tour operator will advise how to make your budget stretch as far as possible. Please remember that apart from tips and some curio shopping, you won't need to spend money in Africa.
- **BE SURE TO INCLUDE TIME TO RELAX.** Some itineraries are a whirlwind that show you everything in a week. You'll have very little time to soak up what you are seeing and to enjoy the experience you've paid for. Don't rush about on safari like you do at home. Linger in each place—three nights is good, four is ideal—and you'll get properly under the skin of a place. You may even find the guides do something really special with you that they can't if you're just spending a couple of nights.



Be sure to balance adventure with plenty of relaxation.

📷 AFRICAN HORSEBACK SAFARIS

- **AFRICA IS MORE THAN JUST ITS ANIMALS.** There's the culture, scenery, smells and sounds all of which make a safari such a special holiday. Go and see the wildlife but if your tour operator suggests something other than just game viewing do give it consideration; you'll be surprised by the amazing experience that awaits you.
- **TRY A TENTED CAMP.** Unlike the tents you may be used to, these have proper beds, fine linen, and en-suite bathrooms. For many, the experience of being cocooned in canvas, listening to the sounds of the bush at night is without equal.

TIPS WHEN YOU GO

- **PACK SENSIBLY.** Luggage allowances are limited and most camps offer a fast laundry service. A good guide is 'one set on, one set off' and one in the wash'. Take comfortable clothes; safaris are informal and fashion is irrelevant. Long trousers are good for evenings and bush walks, and a light rain jacket or jersey for early morning game activities. If you go walking, natural colours help you blend in, and are less visible to the wildlife. Don't do the 'Great White Hunter' thing; you'll look daft.
- **PUT THE CAMERA DOWN.** Of course capturing your safari on camera is great, but please take time to look around occasionally, enjoy the scenery, and look at the wildlife. Get advice about what camera equipment to take to ensure you get the results you want. While some point and shoot cameras will take amazingly good pictures, an SLR camera will ensure the very best results. It's possible to hire a digital SLR camera and suitable lenses if you don't want to buy them. Be sure to check with your guide to find out when it's appropriate to take photos, particularly on a walking safari or with people.
- **DRINK WATER AND WEAR A HAT.** It gets very hot during the day in Africa. Wear a hat, slap on the sunscreen, and drink plenty of water. Take a hint from the wildlife; it rests in the shade during the hottest hours and so should you.
- **TELL YOUR GUIDE WHAT YOU'D LIKE TO SEE.** If it's your first safari and you're keen to see a particular animal, let your guide know. Likewise, if you're a safari veteran tell your guide what you've done before.
- **ASK AARDVARK SAFARIS.** We've decades of first-hand experience between us. As well as being experts in planning holidays in Africa, we're friendly and approachable, and we make arranging a superb holiday to Africa fun and simple. We tailor everything to suit you, and it'll cost no more than putting the trip together yourselves. Please call us, chat with us on Live Chat, or ping us an email – we are sure you'll be as delighted as our clients who travel regularly with us and recommend us to their friends.



Malachite kingfisher, Jacana Camp, Botswana.

CONCLUSION & CONTACT

Now you've read this far, you'll know that planning a safari takes time and expertise. Working out which safari is right for you, when to go, where to stay, staying safe, what to see, getting around, and getting the very best out of your time and money can be challenging. That's where we come in and our clients think we're pretty good at what we do. Read their [testimonials](#) for yourself.

We have met the guides, stayed in the camps and lodges, and seen the wildlife, and we are here to help you. Aardvark Safaris' consultants will create an itinerary based on your wish list, while putting our decades of African travel to good use. We only recommend places that we're passionate about and you'll never pay a penny more for your safari camps, lodges and hotels than you would if you booked direct. We've even got a [guarantee](#) to that effect.

We promise to listen closely, to provide hassle-free planning, honest pricing, great advice, and to bring your safari dreams to life.

**CONTACT US TO BEGIN
YOUR ADVENTURE.**



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